

Does Outside Money Win Elections?

Analyzing Super PAC Spending and Electoral Outcomes
in 2024 U.S. House Races

Data: FEC Campaign Finance • MIT Election Lab • FEC Candidate Summary

The Question

Since Citizens United (2010)

Super PACs can raise and spend unlimited sums on elections, without coordinating with candidates.

By 2024, outside spending on federal elections reached a record **\$4.5 billion**.

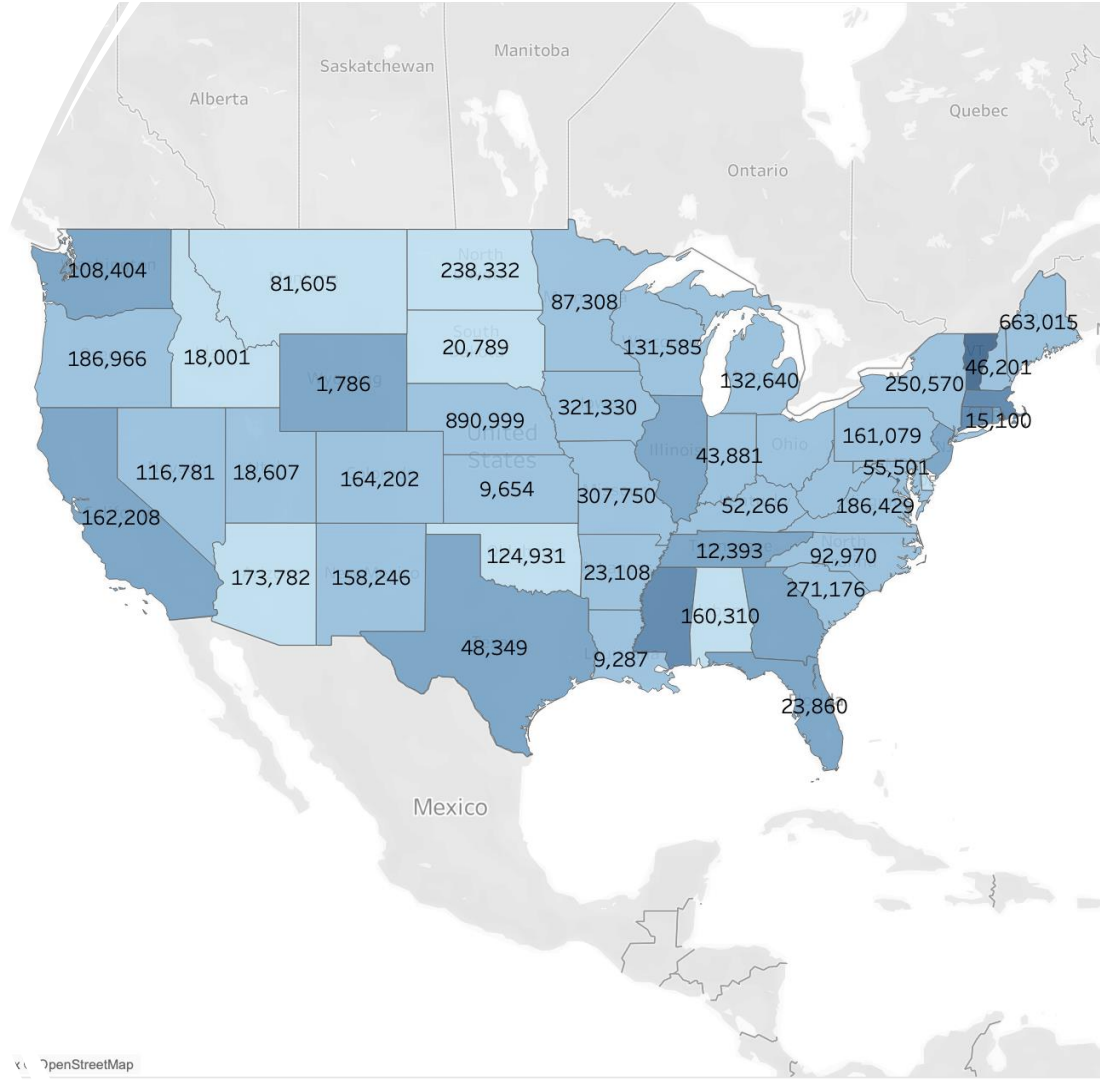
Four Research Questions

1. Is Super PAC spending associated with electoral outcomes?
2. Is Super PAC money more important than candidate's own spending?
3. Where does outside money flow — competitive or safe districts?
4. Are there partisan differences in how Super PAC money is used?

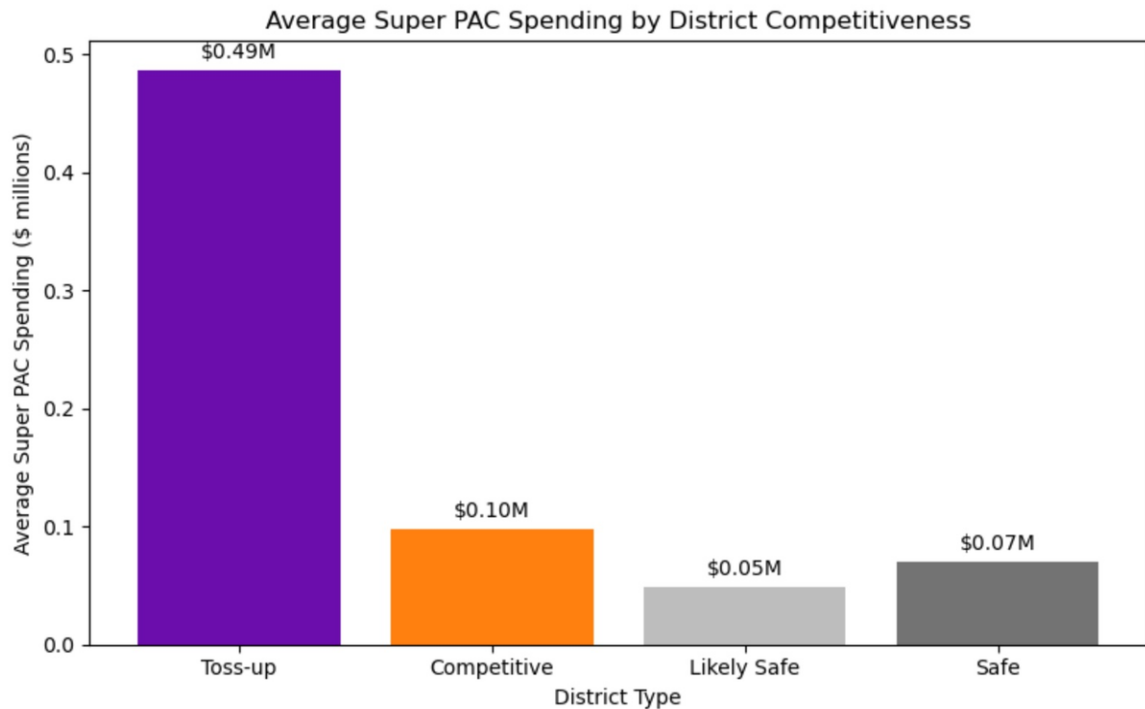
Note: All relationships in this analysis are associative, not causal.

Where Does Super PAC Money Flow?

Average Super PAC spending per candidate by state - 2024 U.S. House races



Finding 1: Money Follows Competitive Races



5×

more money in
Toss-up vs Safe

56%

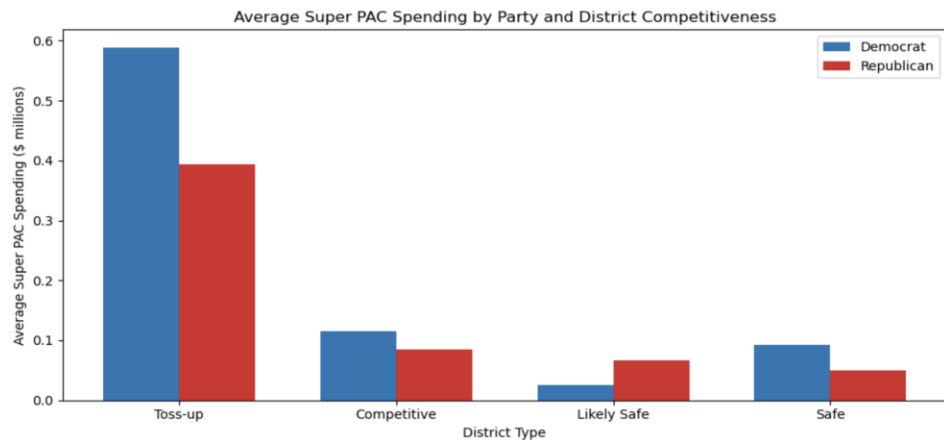
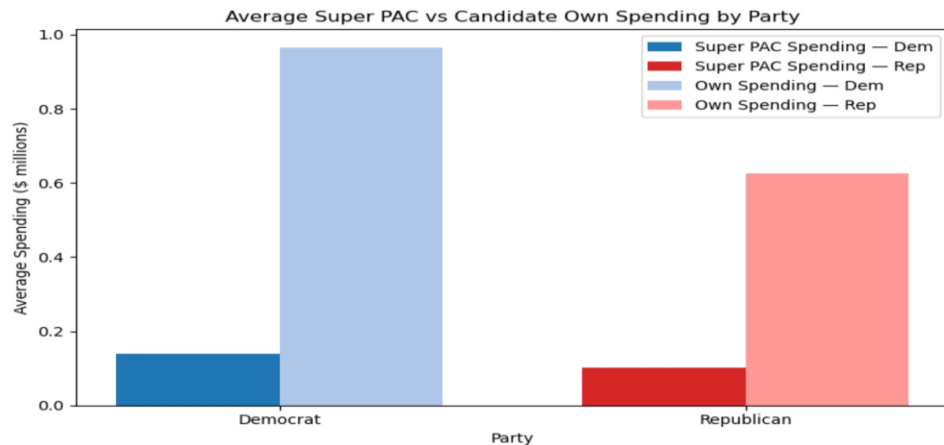
of high-spending
districts are competitive

12%

of low-spending
districts are competitive

Super PACs concentrate resources where outcomes are uncertain.

Finding 2: Partisan Differences in Super PAC Use



Key Insights

Democrats

receive more Super PAC dollars in absolute terms in competitive districts (\$589K vs \$394K)

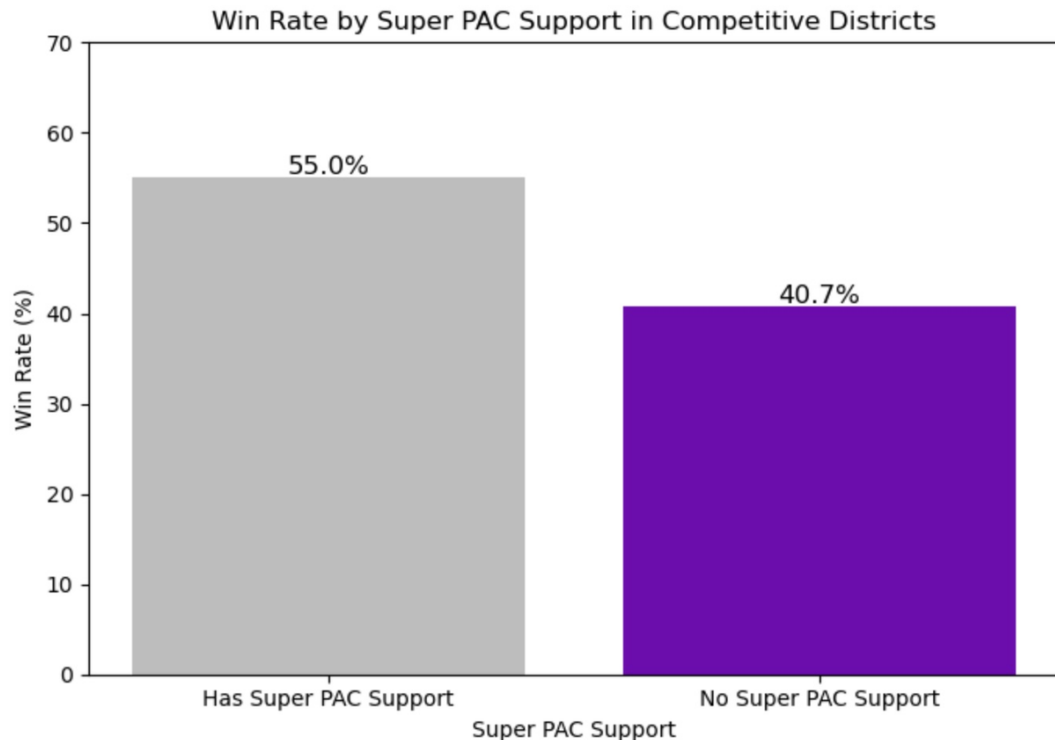
Republicans

show higher relative dependence — Super PAC money = 35% of own spending vs 25% for Democrats

Both parties

concentrate outside money heavily in Toss-up races, with steep drop-off in safe districts

Finding 3: Super PAC Support Is Associated with Winning



+14pp

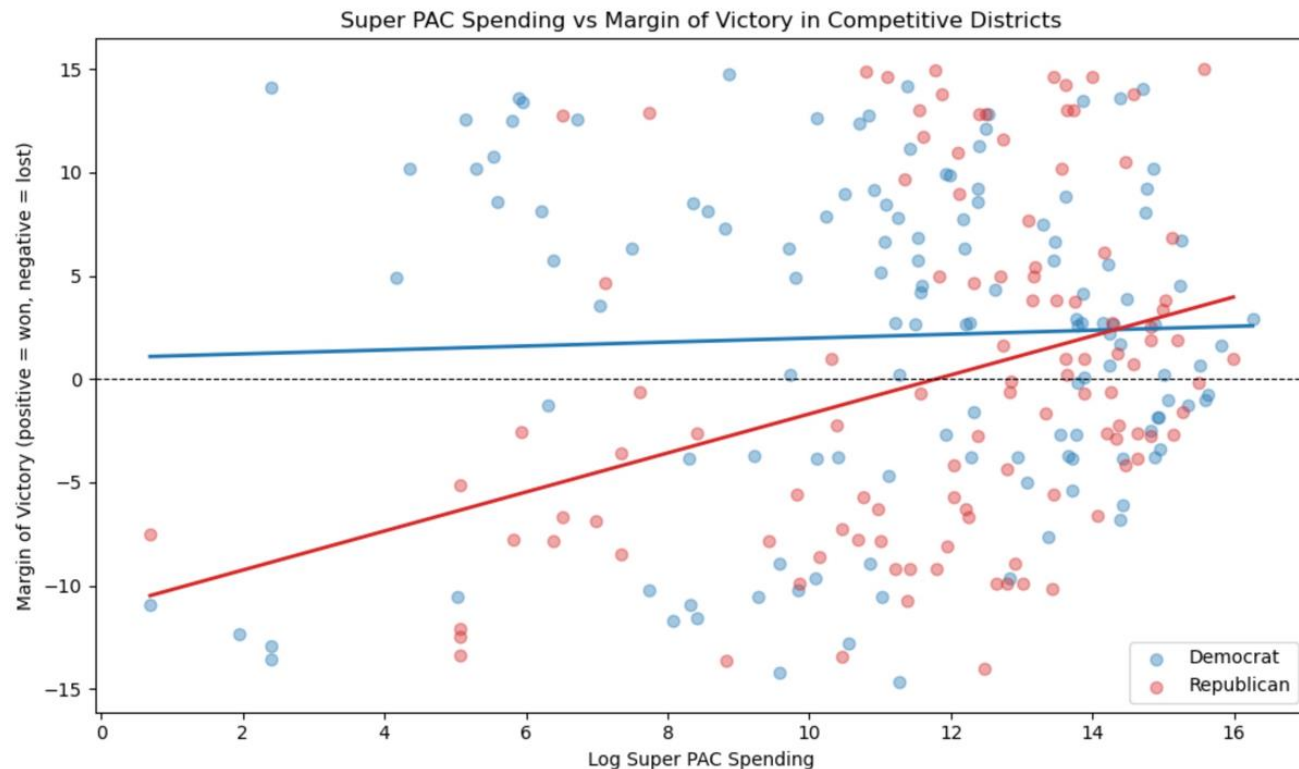
higher win rate with
Super PAC support

Important caveat

Super PACs invest in candidates who are already likely to win. This gap reflects both a real association AND strategic targeting — not necessarily causation.

Analysis limited to competitive districts (Toss-up + Competitive) only.

Finding 4: Weak But Positive Association with Margin



Both trend lines slope upward
— more Super PAC spending is weakly associated with better margin

But the scatter is wide
— candidates with similar spending had very different outcomes

$R^2 = 0.143$
— models explain 14% of variance in margin of victory

Log-transformed Super PAC spending. Trend lines show OLS fit per party.

Finding 5: What Actually Predicts Winning?

Two regression models — competitive districts only (n=824)

Predictor	Linear Regression (Margin of Victory)	Logistic Regression (Win/Loss)
Incumbency Status	2.86 ↑ (strongest)	0.83 ↑ (strongest)
Party Affiliation (Dem)	1.40 ↑	0.55 ↑
Super PAC spending FOR	2.09 ↑	0.53 ↑
Candidate own spending	0.15 ↑	-0.05 ≈ 0
Super PAC spending AGAINST	-0.05 ≈ 0	0.08 ≈ 0
Linear Regression: $R^2 = 0.143$ RMSE = 8.0pp		Logistic Regression: Accuracy = 67% (vs 50% baseline)

Conclusions

Does Super PAC spending predict outcomes?

Descriptively yes, candidates with Super PAC support win 55% vs 41%. But after controlling for party and incumbency, the independent effect is modest.

Is Super PAC money more important than own spending?

No. Candidate's own fundraising is a stronger predictor. Super PAC spending complements, not replaces, a strong campaign.

Where does money flow?

Toss-up districts receive ~5× more Super PAC spending than Safe districts. 56% of high-spending districts are competitive, vs only 12% of low-spending ones.

Partisan differences?

Democrats receive more absolute dollars in competitive races. Republicans show higher relative dependence — Super PAC = 35% of their own spending vs 25% for Democrats.

Limitations & Future Work

01

Missing: District Partisan Lean

Cook Political Report PVI scores would better separate the effect of spending from the underlying political character of each district.

02

Missing: Incumbency Interaction

Future models should test whether Super PAC effects differ between incumbent and challenger races.

03

Extend to 2022 Cycle

Testing whether these patterns hold in a different electoral environment would strengthen or challenge these findings.

04

Explore Primary Races

Super PAC effects may be strongest in primaries, where party brand is less decisive and outside money can more dramatically shift outcomes.